

TREASURES FROM THE ORIENT

This translation of a grand medieval epic is a fantastic portal into the glorious and magical world of Amir Hamza



THE ADVENTURES OF AMIR HAMZA

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Random House

Price: Rs 750; Pages: 948

■ By Gillian Wright

Like Ishaan Awasthi, the hero of *Taare Zameen Par*, the Emperor Akbar was dyslexic—or so the translator of this book believes. Again, like the child, he loved paintings, and commissioned the biggest, most colourful and action-packed Mughal illustrations for his copy of *The Adventures of Amir Hamza*. You didn't have to be literate to appreciate the *dastaan* and that was one of the reasons for its universal popularity. Episodes were recited with great zest by storytellers, and as no oral recitation is exactly the same as any other, the adventures had individuality and the capacity to grow. This translation brings out their optimistic spirit. The world is Hamza's oyster and our hero makes his way from Mecca to Basra, Sri Lanka, China, India, Greece and Egypt, spending 18 years in the land of the *jinn* and *devs* of Qaaf.

Hamza, like Akbar, inhabited a glorious medieval world of forests, rivers and riches. His chivalry and generosity would have appealed at once to the Emperor. Hamza never strikes the first blow, and only once attacks an enemy at night. He loves a good battle, but only after giving peace a chance, and like Akbar, co-opts those who submit to him. Akbar must also have appreciated the myriad tales of spies and court intrigue. Hamza is unusual as an epic hero because he is not of royal stock. Although he loyally serves the king of Ctesiphon, he has enemies at court and the king himself so fears his strength that he keeps plotting to have him done away with.

Luckily, Hamza's team has players much more skilled at mischief and



EXCERPT

The florid news writers, the sweet-lipped historians, revivers of old tales and renewers of past legends, relate that there ruled at Ctesiphon in Persia (image of Heaven!) Emperor Qubad Kamran, who cherished his subjects and was a succor to the impecunious in their distress. He was unsurpassed in dispensing justice, and so rigorous in this exercise that the best justice appeared an injustice compared to his decree. Prosperity and affluence thrived in his dominions while wrong and inequity slumbered in death, and rara avis-like, mendicants and the destitute were extinct in his lands. The wealthy were at a loss to find an object for their charity. The weak and the powerful were equals, and the hawk and the sparrow roosted in the same nest. The young and the old sought one another's pleasure, neither ever deeming himself the sole benefactor. The portals of houses remained open day and night like the eyes of the vigil, for if someone stole even the color of henna from the palm, he was ground in the mill of justice. The thief therefore did not even dream of thieving, and if perchance a wayfarer should come upon someone's property on the road, he took it upon himself to restore it to its owner. Compared with Qubad Kamran's fearlessness, might, and valor, Rustam was the same as a hag most decrepit and cowardly.